

KEEP HER FLYING!

SWING-CLIPPER



DAY 47 OF THE
SWING-CLIPPER RETROFIT

JOB: HULL INTAKE
REINFORCEMENT &
AIRFLOW MOD.

LEAD HAND:
"PATCHWORK" POGO

POGO! THAT
INTAKE LOOKS
LIKE A DRUNK
SHARK BIT IT!

'UGLY'
DON'T LEAK.

HMPH!
YOU CALL THAT
WELDIN'?

YOU GONNA
SCARE AWAY
CUSTOMERS.

MAYBE.

BUT IT
BREATHES
BETTER
NOW.

EVERY BEAD'S
A PROMISE.
I KEEP 'EM.

HMPH!

KIDS TODAY...



SWING-CLIPPER

DAY 1 OF THE RETROFIT



LOOKS LIKE
MY FAVORITE
LOOSE KNOTS
FOUND THEIR WAY
ONTO MY DECK.



THE HOOK.

COULDN'T
KEEP US
AWAY.

RENN

TENSION-TECHNICIAN (APPRENTICE)
RIGHT EYE: BLIND
RIGHT ARM: DEAD



WE
RECEIVED YOUR
BROADCAST.

THE MISSION
ALIGNS WITH OUR
OBJECTIVES.

SLOANE

FORMER ANCHORITE VANGUARD CADET
SPECIALTY: STRUCTURAL INTEGRITY
DISCIPLINE: IMPECCABLE



I-I BROUGHT
THE HIGH-FREQUENCY
TUNERS! AND EXTRA
CRYSTAL LENSES!
AND-

I HOPE THEY'RE
THE RIGHT KIND
I MEAN I CHECKED
THE SPECS BUT-

BIX

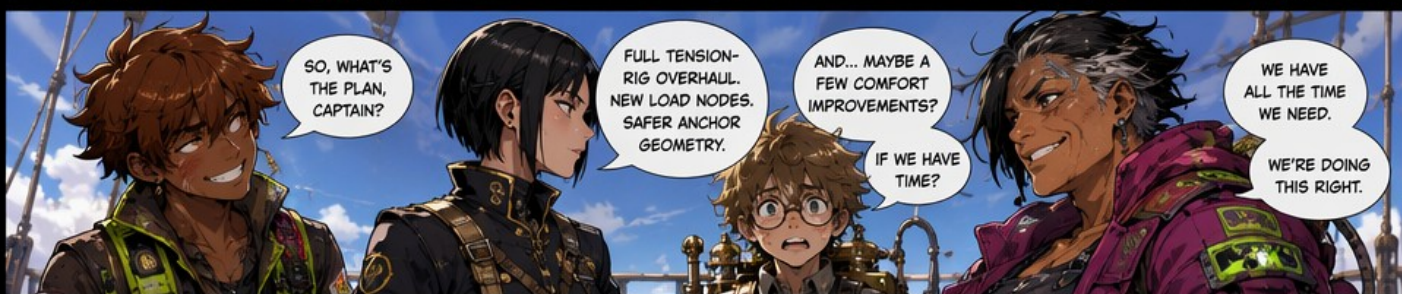
GLASSSMITH (APPRENTICE)
SPECIALTY: RESONANCE & OPTICS
ANXIETY: CHRONIC



HEH.

JUNO "THE HOOK"

CAPTAIN & SALVAGE ENGINEER
LEFT ARM: DREADNOUGHT PROSTHETIC
SPECIALTY: ACQUISITION



SO, WHAT'S
THE PLAN,
CAPTAIN?

FULL TENSION-
RIG OVERHAUL.
NEW LOAD NODES.
SAFER ANCHOR
GEOMETRY.

AND... MAYBE A
FEW COMFORT
IMPROVEMENTS?

IF WE HAVE
TIME?

WE HAVE
ALL THE TIME
WE NEED.

WE'RE DOING
THIS RIGHT.



LET'S GIVE
THE SWING-CLIPPER
THE SECOND LIFE
SHE DESERVES.

**NO KNOT
LEFT BEHIND.**

DAY 1: WORK BEGINS.

SWING-CLIPPER

RETROFIT SEQUENCE

THE SWING-CLIPPER
DOESN'T CARE WHERE
YOU CAME FROM.
ONLY WHAT YOU
CAN HOLD.

NEW SPOOL-LINE.
NEW SUPPORT STRUT.
NEW TUNING CLUSTER.
NEW HEART.

SAME CREW.

RENN
AGE: 16
ROLE: SPOOL LINE
STATUS: ONE EYE BLIND.
ONE ARM STEEL.

SLOANE
AGE: 16
ROLE: SUPPORT STRUT
STATUS: FORMER
ANCHORITE CADET.

BIX
AGE: 14
ROLE: TUNING CLUSTER
STATUS: NERVOUS SYSTEM.

JUNO "THE HOOK"
AGE: 45
ROLE: HEAVY LIFT
STATUS: LOST LEFT ARM.
GAINED BETTER ONE.

1. SPOOL LINE



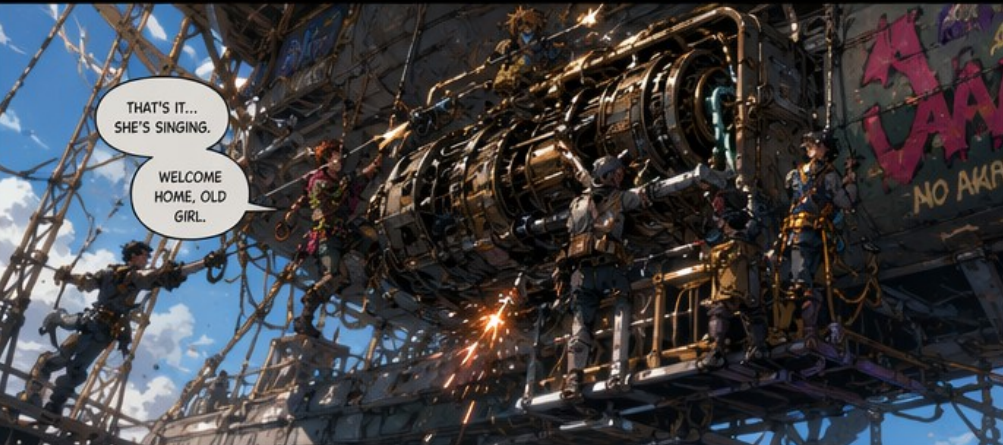
2. SUPPORT STRUT



3. TUNING CLUSTER



4. HEAVY LIFT



PATCHWORK POGO

JUNO & THE HOOK™ & BIX

SWING-CLIPPER
BALLAST-VENT
RIGGING

IF WE
REDIRECT SPOOL
TENSION THROUGH
A SECONDARY SHEAVE
AND BLEED OFF AT
THREE BARS...

...WE GET OUR
BURST WITHOUT
KILLING THE LINE.



THE LINE'LL
SLACK JUST ENOUGH
TO DUMP BALLAST,
THEN SNATCH TIGHT
BEFORE REBOUND.

TIMING'S
TIGHT—BUT YOUR
HOOK CAN TAKE
THE SHOCK.



THE HOOK
DOESN'T TAKE
SHOCK.

THE HOOK
DELIVERS IT.



FASCINATING...
THE PRESSURE
CURVE SHOULD
SPIKE AT
2.8 SECONDS...

...I'LL
LOG IT.



SHEAVE LOCKED.
TENSION REDIRECTED.

YOU'VE GOT
THREE BARS IN THE
GREEN BEFORE THE
BLEED WINDOW.



NOW!

CRACK
THE VENT!



BALLAST VENT: OPERATIONAL.
SWING-CLIPPER: ONE BREATH CLOSER TO FREEDOM.

SKY MARGIN
OUTER DRIFT
REFUGEE RAFT CLUSTER 7

IT DOESN'T
MAKE A SOUND.

NO WAVE.
NO SHADOW.

JUST LIGHT.
GETTING CLOSER.

THE FIELD
TOUCHES.

AND EVERYTHING
FORGETS HOW TO
BE ALIVE.

TOES.
ANKLES.
KNEES.

UPWARD.

NOT INSTANTLY.

MERCIFULLY,
SLOWLY.

THE NULL-SPIRE
DESCENDS.

NOT TO DESTROY.

BUT TO REMEMBER
WHAT SHOULD NOT
BE HERE.

IT HUMS.

A NOTE WITHOUT
WARMTH.

A PROMISE
WITHOUT MERCY.



NULL-SPIRE
ALERT!

DESCENT
VECTOR LOCKED!
ETA: NINE
MINUTES!



THE NEEDLE--
IT'S TREMBLING!

SHE'S CLOSE!
CLOSER THAN
THE CHARTS
CALCULATED!

TICK
TICK

BIX
APPARATUS HAND



YEAH.

That tracks.
She's not
JUST falling.
She's
HUNTING.

RENN
TENSION-CRAFT
OPERATOR



ALL HANDS
TO STATIONS.
PREPARE FOR
TENSION-VAULT
INTERCEPT.
I'M TAKING
THE RAIL.

SLOANE
FORMER ANCHORITE
CADET



RIG TENSION.
BANK HARD.
WE MEET THAT
SPIRE ON OUR
TERMS.

ALL
TOGETHER!

NULL-SPIRE
DESCENT VECTOR
3,200 METERS
AND CLOSING.

TENSION
SET.

LET'S
DANCE.

VECTOR
LOCKED.

I WILL
TAKE THE
LOAD.

SWING-CLIPPER
RETROFIT MODEL 7B
CREW: 2

YANK!

LOOP
SECURED.
PULL ON
THREE.

ONE.

TWO.

THREE!

NULL-FIELD
DISPERSING.
PETRIFICATION
RECEDING.

KRAAARIK!

...WE'RE
BACK?

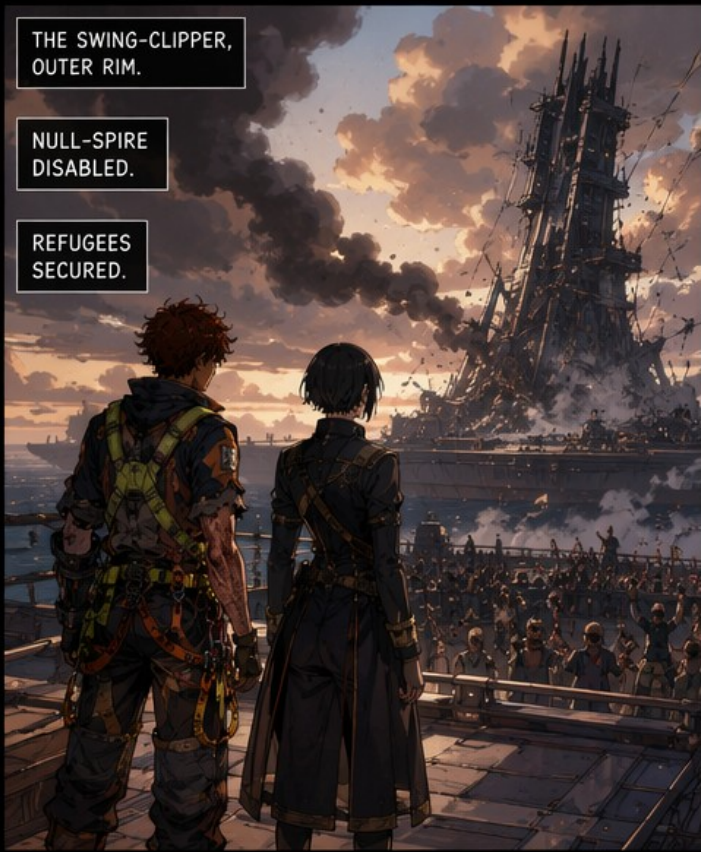
MOM?

NOT TOO LATE.

THE SWING-CLIPPER,
OUTER RIM.

NULL-SPIRE
DISABLED.

REFUGEES
SECURED.



HAH!
THAT'S...
THAT'S REALLY
OVER.

RENN.

AGE: 16
TENSION-CRAFT CLIMBER
RIGHT EYE: BLIND
RIGHT ARM: LOST

IT IS.
WELL DONE,
RENN.

SLOANE.

AGE: 16
EX-ANCHORITE VANGUARD
CADET
SLOANE HOUSE



STILL
GOT ONE
GOOD ARM.

STILL
GOT A VIEW.



AND YOU
STILL KNOW HOW
TO USE IT.

THAT IS WHAT
MATTERS.



HEH.

WOULDN'T
WANT TO LET
YOU DOWN.

DON'T BE
RIDICULOUS.

I EXPECTED
NOTHING LESS.



ANOTHER SPIRE
FALLS.

ANOTHER DEBT
IS OWED.

ANOTHER STEP
FORWARD.





TEN MINUTES
LATER.



THAT WAS
SICK!

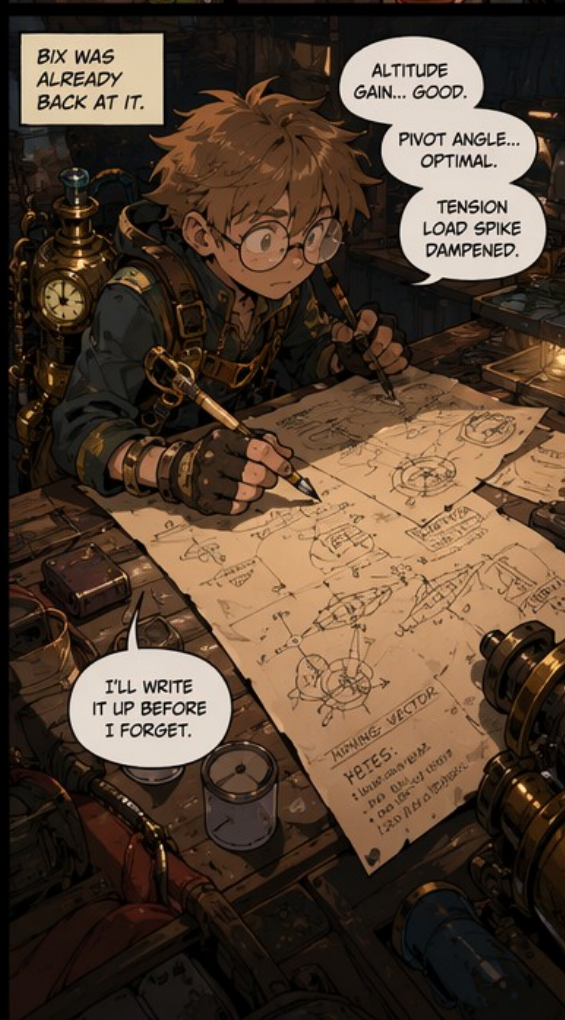
YOU TWO
ARE INSANE!

WAP
WAP

THAT'S
MY CREW.

SOLID
AS KNOTS.

TSSSSS



BIX WAS
ALREADY
BACK AT IT.

ALTITUDE
GAIN... GOOD.

PIVOT ANGLE...
OPTIMAL.

TENSION
LOAD SPIKE
DAMPENED.

I'LL WRITE
IT UP BEFORE
I FORGET.

NOTES:
1. LOW...
2. HIGH...
3. 1200...
4. 1200...
5. 1200...



RENN! HOW'S
THE ARM?

STILL DEAD.

STILL
USELESS.

NOTHING
NEW.

DON'T
LISTEN TO
POGO.

YOU FLEW
THAT CLIPPER
LIKE A POET.



HEH. LET 'EM.
WE ONLY ANSWER
TO EACH OTHER.

SWING-CLIPPER!
CREW!

WELL
EXECUTED,
SWING-CLIPPER
CREW.

THE ANCHORITE
VANGUARD
WILL TAKE
NOTICE.

SLOANE.

SWING-CLIPPER
"PATCHWORK"

PROVISIONING RUN.
GULLPORT DOCKS.

COME ON,
PEOPLE! THE WIND
WON'T WAIT FOR
STRAGGLERS!

MATRON
"MAMA" VEX
PROVISIONS
MASTER

HEAVE!

LIFT WITH
YOUR LEGS!

WATCH YOUR
BLOODY FINGERS!

PATCHWORK
"POGO"
MECHANIC

JUNO
"THE HOOK"
RIGGER

HIGH-CLIMB
RATIONS
Hook & Lash Co.

POGO!
THE SPARE
AIR-TANKS— WHERE
ARE THEY SUPPOSED
TO GO?

STOW 'EM
UNDER THE
FO'CSLE! NEXT TO
THE OXY-KIT— NO,
LEFT! LEFT!

BIX
FABRICATOR

BIX! HOW MANY
BREATHERS CAN
YOU FINISH BEFORE
WE CAST OFF?

I-I DON'T
KNOW! TEN?
TWELVE! MAYBE
MORE IF THE GLASS
HOLDS!

JUST DON'T
DROP ANY...

ROPE'S
CLEAR!

THEN
MOVE!

WE EAT
TO CLIMB!

HIGHER
TOGETHER

The Swing-Clipper "High Garden"

Deck Crew Manifest, Night Shift
Relay Line Installation
Third Run

OUT HERE, EVERY
CABLE IS A LIFELINE.

KITE
Deck Hand
(Relay Runner)
Age: 8

MATRON "MAMA" VEX
Quartermaster
Provisioner
Disciplinarian
(All Around Terror)

COMMS LINE
THROUGH!
RUNNING HOT!
ON MY WAY!

THUMP!

THUMP!

RELAY ONE
ONLINE!

CHK!

HMM.
THIRD RUN
AHEAD OF
SCHEDULE.
NOT BAD.

DECK MANIFEST SUPPLY & SYSTEMS

- Comms Cable
- Relay Boxes
- Insulators
- Crimps
- Power Cells
- Lantern Fuel
- Deck Plates

VEX

YES'M,
MAMA VEX!
WON'T LET
YOU DOWN!

MISSING
FRONT TOOTH.
EARNED IT.
(LONG STORY)

AND...
WE HAVE
LIGHT!

BLINK!



ONE SMALL
SWITCH.
ONE SMALL JOB.
DONE RIGHT!

THAT'S HOW
WE STAY
IN THE SKY!

DON'T GET
COCKY, SCRAP.

ONE CROSSED WIRE
AND WE ALL DANCE
WITH THE FALL.



THE PROVISIONING DECK.
EVERYONE'S GOT A JOB.

BRASS. GEARS.
GLOWING DIALS.
EVERYONE'S
BUILDING.
FIXING.
IMPROVING.

...EXCEPT
ME.

AND CODA.



FUNNY
HOW QUIET
IT GETS...

WHEN YOU
STOP TRYING
TO KEEP UP.



CODA
DOESN'T
MIND.

CODA
NEVER
MINDS.

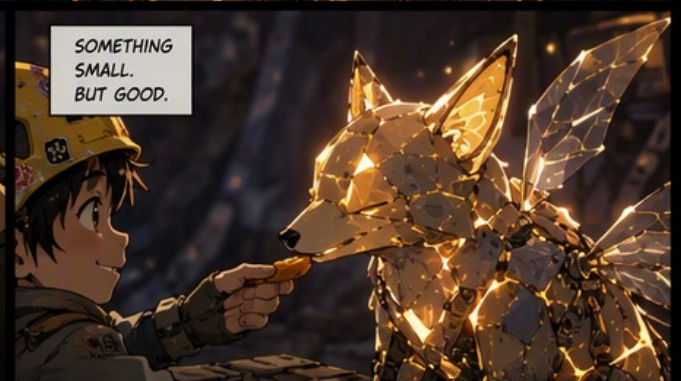


DRIED
APRICOT.
THE GOOD
KIND.
SWEET.
CHEWY.
WORTH
SHARING.

CRACK



SNAP



SOMETHING
SMALL.
BUT GOOD.



CODA
TAKES IT
SO GENTLY.



AND JUST
LIKE THAT...

I'M NOT
LEFT OUT
ANYMORE.

I'M JUST...
KITE.
AND CODA.



YOU'RE BEYOND
THE CIVIL TRAFFIC
LANES, CITIZEN.

THIS IS A
RESTRICTED
PERIMETER.

I-I DIDN'T
MEAN TO! I
JUST GOT
LOST! I SWEAR,
I'M NOT WITH
THEM!

P-PLEASE
DON'T TURN
ME IN!

I HAVE NO
INTENTION OF
DOING ANYTHING
UNREASONABLE.

I'M SIMPLY
EXPLAINING THE
SITUATION.

THE DRIFT-FLEET IS NOT
A PLACE FOR STRAYS.

RESOURCES ARE
ACCOUNTED FOR.
MOVEMENT IS
MONITORED.

YOUR PRESENCE
HERE CREATES
RISK—FOR YOU,
AND FOR US.

R-RISK?
WHAT RISK
COULD I...

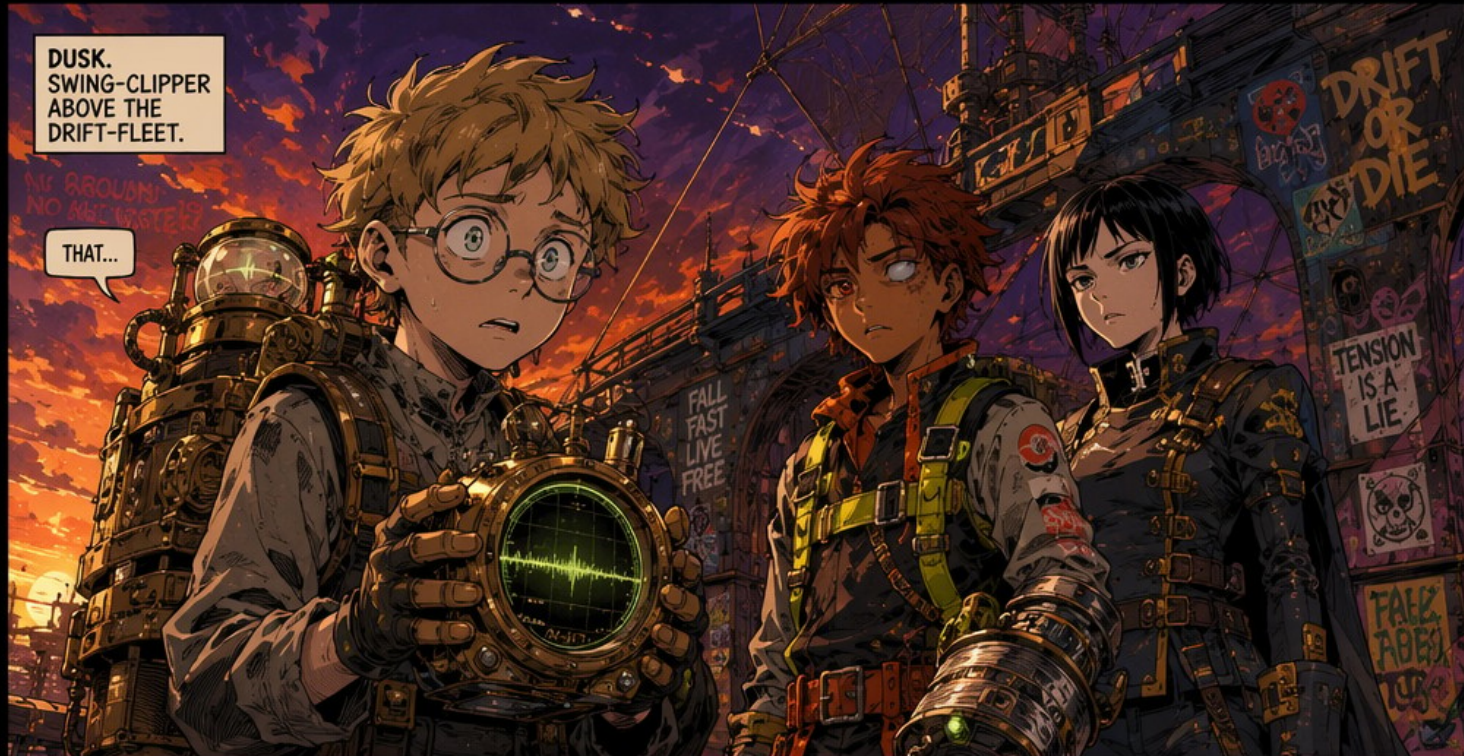
THE KIND THAT
GETS PEOPLE
VAPORIZED.
USUALLY BY
ACCIDENT.

PERIMETER ALERT

UNAUTHORIZED CONTACT
POTENTIAL THREAT

LUCKILY FOR YOU,
THAT HASN'T HAPPENED.

YET.



DUSK.
SWING-CLIPPER
ABOVE THE
DRIFT-FLEET.

THAT...



...THIS ISN'T
A TENSION
SPIKE.

IT'S A
WAKE.



PLANET-SCALE.
SLOW.
MOVING.
ALIVE.

IT'S...



...HEADING
THIS WAY.



SO.
THE DRIFT
FINALLY
WOKE UP.

FIGURES IT
WOULD WAIT
'TIL NOW.



THIS IS
BEYOND ANY
ANCHORITE
PROTOCOL.

THERE WILL
BE NO REINFOR-
CEMENTS.



THEN IT'S
ON US.
AS IT
ALWAYS
WAS.



THE DRIFT
DOESN'T KNOCK.
IT PULLS.

AND NOW—
IT'S CALLING
THEM HOME.

END OF EPISODE.